



Grade 7
General
English Language Arts

Directions:

On the following pages of your practice test booklet are questions for the Grade 7 *Nebraska Student-Centered Assessment System (NSCAS) General English Language Arts* practice test.

Read these directions carefully before beginning the test.

This practice test will include several different types of questions. Some questions are based on a passage. Multiple choice questions will ask you to select an answer from among four choices. Multiple select questions will ask you to select multiple correct answers from among five or more answer choices. For some questions, there may be two parts, Part A and Part B, where each part has a multiple choice or multiple select question. Some questions will ask you to construct an answer by following the directions given.

For all questions:

- Read each question carefully and choose the best answer.
- You may use scratch paper to make notes.
- Be sure to answer ALL the questions.

Read the passage.

The Storyteller

- 1** The leaves had fallen from every tree except the oaks on the high ridges standing tall above the grassland. The last of the geese were veeing up to fly south as morning frost sparkled on the needles of the red pine. Winter crept toward the plains, so the time had come for Red Bird the storyteller and her people to make the long trek into the hills, where they would be sheltered during the freezing winter months. As final preparations for moving ensued, the wind turned cold and began blowing from the east. Winter was on its way.
- 2** On the second day of the journey, winter warned them it was coming. Dark, rolling clouds crowded the sky. Gusts of wind laid the grasses flat and snarled through the branches of trees. The elders talked among themselves. The winter lodges were still ten grueling days ahead on foot. Parents urged the children to hurry along. The chief could feel winter on his heels and feared it would overtake his people. He set a brisk pace but slowed when it became too difficult for some. One person suggested they break into groups, leaving three or four leaders behind to help the very old and the very young.
- 3** “We’ll leave no one behind. It will be safest for all of us if we stay together,” the chief reasoned. “We must all help each other, support each other.”
- 4** No matter how fast they walked, winter walked faster. On the fourth day, it overtook them. The wind subsided and snow fell, turning later into sleet and forming piles around the bushes and clumps of grass. The path became slippery and muddy. Winter hung above them, dark and threatening, and rose up, white and cold in the growing snow.
- 5** Everyone was drenched and drowsy by the time they made camp. Each family made its shelter and huddled around a small fire. They exchanged looks, but no one complained about their ordeal. The wind picked up again just before morning. By the time the procession started, the wind had become a gale, and the snow blocked the view in all directions. Winter hemmed them in. The group made little progress, and by noon the snow had climbed to their knees. The elders decided it would be best to wait out the storm. Perhaps winter would pass over soon enough.
- 6** “Tonight we’ll stay together in one shelter,” the chief decided. “We’ll be safest if we huddle together, each person keeping his or her neighbors warm. It will be difficult finding firewood, so we will work together to fuel one fire.”

- 7 A large pine had been blown over and was caught between two neighboring trees. The women cut its limbs to use as the frame for the shelter. They propped the limbs against the trunk and covered them with hides. The hides were in turn covered with pine boughs to seal the cracks and hold the walls in place. The children removed the snow from the floor of the makeshift shelter. The men spread out, searching for firewood, looking up for low-hanging dry limbs. By the time the last person returned, the snow was waist deep and drifting, and the wind had turned colder.
- 8 The people spent two nights in the shelter while winter **assailed** them from all sides, dumping four feet of snow and blowing drifts twice that high in places. Though they tried valiantly, the people could gather very little firewood. On the third night, the temperature plummeted. Winter was going to freeze them out. Only a tiny flame flickered weak sparks of light. Winter had trapped them and taken their hope.
- 9 But Red Bird had not given up. As the fire exhausted into a single stream of smoke, Red Bird sang. Everyone knew the traditional song—it told of the way the sun had been placed in the sky and how it warmed the earth so that life sprang forth. When the song ended, Red Bird fought winter with her words. She wove stories of summer days when the sun was so bright it singed the tips of the cornstalks. She spoke of warm red rocks radiating heat and of the animals who took shelter in shaded places. With her words she pushed away winter and carried her listeners through a desert where even the cactus bowed down in the heat. Her verbal tapestry wrapped around everyone inside the shelter and kept them warm. Despite her exhaustion and the bone-chilling cold, Red Bird fought winter through the night, causing the imagination of her listeners to glow in the warmth of her descriptions. Red Bird spoke so beautifully and so bravely that nature listened. Sunshine greeted them in the morning. Red Bird fell silent. She was exhausted, but she had prevailed over winter and saved her people.
- 10 A day later, they continued their journey, carrying Red Bird, tired from her night of battling winter. Red Bird recovered and lived to tell many more stories, but none as important as the fires she created during the **arduous** winter nights.

1. What does paragraph 8 imply MOST about the people?
 - A. They have lost trust in the chief.
 - B. They realize their situation is serious.
 - C. They know they will survive the storm.
 - D. They think the lodge would have been safer.

2. Select **three** details that create suspense in the passage.
 - A. The leaves had fallen from every tree except the oaks on the high ridges standing tall above the grassland.
 - B. The chief could feel winter on his heels and feared it would overtake his people.
 - C. By the time the procession started, the wind had become a gale, and the snow blocked the view in all directions.
 - D. The women cut its limbs to use as the frame for the shelter.
 - E. The children removed the snow from the floor of the makeshift shelter.
 - F. Winter was going to freeze them out.

3. In paragraph 9, what do the author’s word choices show about Red Bird?
 - A. The words “traditional” and “exhaustion” show that Red Bird is much older than others.
 - B. The words “fought” and “pushed” show that Red Bird is more frustrated by the circumstances than others.
 - C. The words “imagination” and “descriptions” show that Red Bird inspires creativity in the group.
 - D. The words “greeted” and “prevailed” show that Red Bird succeeds in bringing warmth to the group.

4. What is the meaning of **assailed** as used in paragraph 8?
- A. attacked
 - B. followed
 - C. greeted
 - D. surprised
5. In paragraph 9, what is the meaning of the metaphor “Her verbal tapestry wrapped around everyone”?
- A. The people were absorbed by Red Bird’s words.
 - B. The people were lulled to sleep by Red Bird’s tales.
 - C. Red Bird told stories that were familiar to the people.
 - D. Red Bird spoke loudly so the people could hear over the storm.

6. This question has two parts. Answer Part A, and then answer Part B.

Part A

Which sentence BEST states the theme of the passage?

- A. Hard times can make people stronger.
- B. A good leader will sacrifice and persist in times of need.
- C. It is important to plan ahead before departing on a long journey.
- D. Resourceful people can find in nature everything they need to survive.

Part B

Which sentence from the passage BEST supports the answer to Part A?

- A. Winter crept toward the plains, so the time had come for Red Bird the storyteller and her people to make the long trek into the hills, where they would be sheltered during the freezing winter months.
- B. Everyone was drenched and drowsy by the time they made camp.
- C. By the time the last person returned, the snow was waist deep and drifting, and the wind had turned colder.
- D. Despite her exhaustion and the bone-chilling cold, Red Bird fought winter through the night, causing the imagination of her listeners to glow in the warmth of her descriptions.

7. What does the word **arduous** mean in paragraph 10?

- A. difficult
- B. frequent
- C. meaningful
- D. unusual

The items on this page are not passage-based.

★ 8. **Read the sentence Jax wrote.**

Lucy put together a team to design a colorful mural.

Jax wants to add to the sentence to say that Lucy is a talented artist. What is the BEST way for Jax to revise the sentence?

- A. Lucy, a talented artist, put together a team to design a colorful mural.
- B. Designing a colorful mural, Lucy, a talented artist, put together a team.
- C. Putting together a team to design a colorful mural, Lucy is a talented artist.
- D. To design a colorful mural, Lucy put together a team, and she is a talented artist.

★ 9. **Read the paragraph.**

Did you know that languages have families? Sure, languages are not living things, but they can still have parents, siblings, and children. Take Latin for example, a language spoken by many people in Europe and North Africa hundreds and hundreds of years ago. No one today grows up speaking Latin, but lots of people learn Latin's child languages: Spanish, French, Italian, Portuguese, and Romanian. Over time, Latin changed so much that it split into these multiple new languages. These child languages are fully grown and having children of their own when they have prolonged contact with other languages, such as French Creole. _____

Which sentence BEST fits in the blank to provide a conclusion for the paragraph?

- A. People who speak related languages may notice similarities between those languages.
- B. Language families can be large or small, but all languages fit into a family tree of some kind.
- C. Other non-living things can also be organized into families to help us understand their relationships.
- D. Latin was important in many parts of the world because it was the language used by the Roman Empire.

The item on this page is not passage-based.

★ 10. **Read the paragraph.**

Many people complain about not having enough free time. Middle-school students definitely have this problem. Their time is too occupied with school and homework. Often they are signed up for organized activities that take up every spare moment not spent on academics. This focus on school plus the overscheduling makes it challenging for middle-school students to develop their interests and nurture their creativity. _____

Which sentence, when added to the end of the paragraph, BEST develops the problem/solution structure?

- A. Strong family relationships help middle-school students deal with the demands of high school.
- B. Families may also experience financial pressure to pay for middle-school students' organized activities.
- C. Middle-school students should have shorter school days, less homework, and fewer organized activities.
- D. Middle-school students face other issues, including a need for extra sleep to support growth and brain development.

Read the passage.

Willa Cather: Nebraska Pioneer and Author

- 1 One of Nebraska’s most beloved authors is Willa Cather. In 1883, when Willa was nine years old, she traveled with her family from the Blue Ridge Mountains in Virginia to the American frontier in Webster County, Nebraska. It was a dramatic change for Willa. Later, in a book called *My Ántonia*, she would write about the experience.
- 2 After two years of farming, the Cather family moved to the nearby town of Red Cloud. Willa thrived in Red Cloud, exploring the countryside, meeting new people, and developing an appreciation for the arts. Cather graduated from Red Cloud High School and the University of Nebraska. Red Cloud and the country surrounding it made a deep impression on Cather. She used its landscape as a setting in many of her novels and short stories.
- 3 Cather is one of Nebraska’s most noted novelists, yet when she first began college, she wanted to become a doctor. When one of the stories Cather wrote for a class got published, she discovered a passion for writing. The remaining time she was in college, Cather used her new-found talent to edit the school magazine and write articles and play reviews for the local paper.
- 4 After graduating in 1895, Cather moved to Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania, where she was offered an editing position for *Home Monthly*. She wrote many short stories during this time and used them in the magazine. She was also a telegraph operator and theater critic for the *Daily Leader*.
- 5 From 1897 to 1906, Cather worked as a high school English and Latin teacher. During that time, she continued to write and publish stories. In 1903 Cather published a volume of poetry called *April Twilights*, and in 1905 she published a collection of short stories called *The Troll Garden*.
- 6 Cather’s writing came to the attention of S.S. McClure, the owner of one of the most widely read magazines in the United States. In 1906 Cather moved to New York City and became a writer and editor for *McClure’s Magazine*. While on an assignment in Boston, she met Sara Orne Jewett, who encouraged her to write about her roots in Nebraska. In 1912 Cather left *McClure’s Magazine* to write full time.
- 7 Cather published her first novel, *Alexander’s Bridge*, in 1912. One year later, she published *O Pioneers!*—a novel set in the windswept frontier of Nebraska. During that time, she met up with an old friend from Red Cloud named Annie Sadilek. Cather based the main character of her next book, *My Ántonia*, on her friend. *My Ántonia*, published in 1918, was another story about Nebraska. It celebrated the land and the immigrant pioneers, and it is considered one of Cather’s finest works.

- 8 In 1923 Cather won the Pulitzer Prize for *One of Ours*, her novel about a Nebraska farm boy who goes off to fight in World War I. She went on to write several more books and win many awards for her writing. Each of her books was met with widespread praise and admiration.
- 9 Many of her books drew on her memories and knowledge of Nebraska. Cather has been thought of as a **chronicler** of the American pioneer. Her novels express her deep love of the land and exhibit a strong sense of place. She created strong female characters and emphasized the importance of family and the need for human courage and dignity.
- 10 Cather was the first woman admitted into the Nebraska Hall of Fame. The Willa Cather Pioneer Memorial and Education Foundation is located in Red Cloud, Nebraska. There, her childhood home and other buildings connected to her writings have been preserved. Surrounding the site are 210 acres of native grassland called the Willa Cather Memorial Prairie. Standing on the prairie, people today can imagine what it was like a hundred years before, when Cather wrote, "Elsewhere the sky is the roof of the world; but here the earth was the floor of the sky."

11. How does paragraph 2 MOST contribute to the ideas in the passage?
- A. It focuses on Cather’s education, which set her up for success in the future.
 - B. It describes Cather’s life in Nebraska, which heavily influenced her later writing.
 - C. It explains how the move to Red Cloud was a major turning point in Cather’s life.
 - D. It emphasizes the impact her family’s many moves had on Cather’s decision to become a writer.
12. Based on the passage, what does the author find MOST remarkable about Willa Cather?
- A. She overcame deep hardships to find success in life.
 - B. She followed her heart and became a writer instead of a doctor.
 - C. She devoted several years of her life to being a high school teacher.
 - D. She used her background to write works that became hugely popular.
13. What caused Cather to change her goal of becoming a doctor?
- A. She got a job in Pennsylvania.
 - B. She graduated from high school.
 - C. She had a story published in college.
 - D. She met up with a friend from Red Cloud.

14. What does **chronicler** mean as it is used in paragraph 9?
- A. a winner of many awards
 - B. a preserver of the old ways
 - C. a supporter of local causes
 - D. a writer of historical accounts
15. Why does the author MOST LIKELY describe the Willa Cather Pioneer Memorial and Education Foundation in paragraph 10?
- A. to encourage tourists and Nebraska residents to visit the area
 - B. to support the idea that Cather has a lasting legacy in Nebraska
 - C. to emphasize the importance of remembering Nebraska's history
 - D. to link Cather's success to her connection with the Nebraska prairie
16. Which sentence BEST states the central idea of the passage?
- A. Novels by Willa Cather are an essential part of the record of pioneer life on the Nebraska prairie.
 - B. Willa Cather is known for her award-winning writing, including works based on her years spent in Nebraska.
 - C. Pioneer life was rich and rewarding, and the author Willa Cather captured it beautifully in her many works.
 - D. The Willa Cather Pioneer Memorial and Education Foundation is a suitable tribute to one of Nebraska's best-known authors.

The items on this page are not passage-based.

★ 17. Read the draft of an essay a student wrote about a camping trip.

[1] Last weekend my parents took me and my two cousins on a camping trip. [2] It was so amazing! [3] All day we did fun activities. [4] At night, we sat around the campfire to look at the stars. [5] When we got back home, the noise of the city made me miss the peace and quiet of the great outdoors. [6] The most exciting part of the trip was when a huge hawk landed on a branch just a few feet from my tent. [7] The whole weekend was really incredible. [8] I was disappointed when it was finally time to pack up and leave.

Which revision would MOST improve the content of the essay?

- A. explaining where the campsite was located in sentence 1
- B. mentioning the names of the parents and two cousins in sentence 1
- C. including examples of some of the activities in sentence 3
- D. identifying the specific species of hawk in sentence 6

★ 18. Read the paragraph.

Not many people enjoy doing daily or weekly chores around the house. _____ there are ways to have fun while getting your work done. You can put on your favorite tunes and dance your way to completion. You can enlist the help of a friend or family member and have a race to see who can finish faster. You can take before and after photographs to give yourself a feeling of accomplishment. The possibilities are endless. Try one and you may be surprised!

Which **two** transitional words BEST fit in the blank?

- A. Besides,
- B. Finally,
- C. However,
- D. Nevertheless,
- E. Unfortunately,

The item on this page is not passage-based.

- ★ 19. Read the paragraph from the first draft of a student's essay.

The Chimney Rock tourist attraction can be found near Bayard, Nebraska. Although it is fairly easy to travel to Chimney Rock now. Once believed the task to be impossible. Many believed that the landmark was a sort of mirage because it never seemed to get closer.

Which sentence BEST corrects the two underlined sentence fragments?

- A. Although it is fairly easy to travel to Chimney Rock now, people once believed the task to be impossible.
- B. Although it is fairly easy to travel to Chimney Rock now; people once believed the task to be impossible.
- C. Although it is fairly easy to travel to Chimney Rock now . . . people once believed the task to be impossible.
- D. Although it is fairly easy to travel to Chimney Rock now, however people once believed the task to be impossible.

The item on this page is not passage-based.

★ 20. **Read the draft of a student’s story.**

Hannah’s grandfather had arrived a few days ago for a weeklong visit. Hannah was enjoying her time with Granddad because they were a lot alike and got along well. They were both huge sports fans, and both especially enjoyed basketball. All day Hannah had been looking forward to watching a playoff basketball game on TV with Granddad. Finally, it was time for the game to start, so Hannah and Granddad settled onto the couch with their favorite snacks. Just then, Hannah’s dad entered the room.

Which line of dialogue should the student add next to show how Hannah would MOST LIKELY respond?

- A. “Granddad, my favorite player is talking to the coach!” Hannah said.
- B. “I’m really hungry, Dad. What are we having for dinner?” Hannah said.
- C. “Granddad, I’m pretty sure that our team is going to win this game!” Hannah said.
- D. “We just sat down to watch the game, Dad. Why don’t you join us?” Hannah said.

**NSCAS General Grade 7
Practice Test Answer Key
ELA**



Sequence	Key	Points
1	B	1
2	B, C, F	2
3	D	1
4	A	1
5	A	1
6	Part A: B Part B: D	2
7	A	1
8	A	1
9	B	1
10	C	1
11	B	1
12	D	1
13	C	1
14	D	1
15	B	1
16	B	1
17	C	1
18	C, D	2
19	A	1
20	D	1